Gradually Increasing Individuality: Suggestions for Improving Alternative Teacher Education Programs

Jeff Henning-Smith, University of Minnesota

COLLEGE OF EDUCATION + HUMAN DEVELOPMENT
UNIVERSITY OF MINNESOTA
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Abstract

The purpose of this article was to examine the use of a gradual release of responsibility (GRR) model (Pearson & Gallagher, 1983) embedded in a co-teaching framework (Washut Heck & Bacharach, 20165) during the student-teaching portion of an alternative teaching licensure program. The goal was to improve an already existing student-teacher field experience summer residency program at a large Midwestern university by better attending to its desire to help all teachers become better equipped with their selection of teaching strategies.

Key Terms

Gradual Release of Responsibility (GRR)
- Is a structured method of instruction designed around a process of shifting **responsibility** (in stages) from the teacher to the learner.
  (Pearson & Gallagher, 1983)

Co-Teaching
- "Defined as two teachers (teacher candidate and cooperating teacher) **working together** with groups of students; sharing the planning, organization, delivery, and assessment of instruction, as well as the physical space".
  (Bacharach, Heck & Dank, 2004)

Stage Developmentalism
- The normalized beliefs in how one progresses through **assumed** stages.
  (Vagle, 2012)

Background

Once again, the alarms are going off, warning of the growing national teacher shortages and of **schools struggling to fill their teacher vacancies.** Sutcher, et al. (2016) said, "unless major changes in teacher supply or a reduction in demand for additional teachers occur over the coming years, **annual teacher shortages could increase to as much as 112,000 teachers by 2018.**

The response has been twofold:
1. States have begun to change the parameters for teacher licensing in an attempt to expedite the process, and enlarge the applicant pool for individuals becoming teachers by removing previous requirements for licensure (Kamenetz, 2014).
2. **Universities have begun to increase the availability of "alternative" teacher licensing programs they offer** (Aragon, 2016).

Problem

Making teaching a more attractive profession to a wider audience, or lowering the standards to becoming a teacher, might ease fears over classroom shortages in the short term, but, "**if teachers are hired without having been fully prepared**, the much higher turnover rates that result are costly in terms of school budgets and decreases in student achievement" (Sutcher, et al., 2016)

There is a disingenuous feeling that comes from teaching teachers to treat their students as individuals, differentiating their instruction for student needs, when pre-service teachers are being trained in a manner that **is rooted in the unconscious acceptance of stage developmentalism**.

Theoretical Framework

Gadamer (1975) wrote about the concept, ***fore-meaning***, as it related to the uniqueness of each individual in making meaning. Gadamer (1975) said, "all that is asked is that we remain open to the meaning of the other person or text"."

Bakhtin (1993), wrote about ***answerability***, or the obligated uniqueness each person has to themselves and others. Bakhtin argued, "uniqueness...is compellingly obligatory… everyone occupies a unique and never-repeatable place, any being is once-occurrent"

Research Question

How might the theoretical concepts of Gadamer (Fore-meaning) and Bakhtin (Answerability) be used to reconceive the utilization of the GRR model in a co-teaching environment designed to support the growth of preservice teachers?

Emergent Interpretations

Fore-meaning is Contingent
(i.e., profoundly contextual and dependent)

- Too frequently programs allow themselves to construct an image of a "normal" preservice teacher in order to create systems of support.
- Programs need to meet each candidate where they are before they start teaching, and begin to **form individual plans of support based around them**.

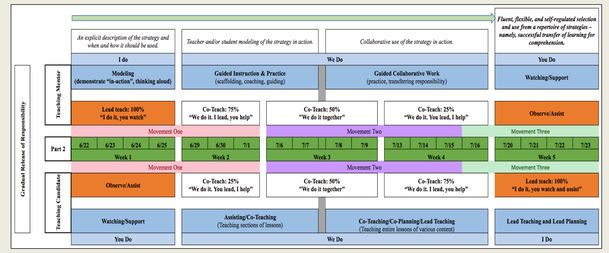
The GRR model through a Recursive and Temporal Lens
(i.e., occurring over and over in and over time)

- In recognizing the uniqueness of each candidate, programs must take the basic GRR model, and go deeper into what it means to be a teacher by engaging in the act of teaching on a recursive level.
- One possible change programs could make is to **be more explicit with candidates when they are being asked to engage in particular aspects of co-teaching**. For example, when teacher candidates are primarily observing their cooperating teacher, what exactly are they observing? How are they deciding what to watch, ask questions about, replicate, and challenge in their own future teaching?

Answerability is Relational
(i.e., equity is central to supporting growth)

- Lastly, it is not enough to acknowledge the inherent uniqueness in each and every individual, and then continue to design support around a progression of development based on an assumption of universal needs.
- Programs need to place the responsibility for "developmental" support on their ability to **interact with each candidate equitably.**

Paradigms and Potentials



Educational Importance

- Teachers develop and change over time, but this change and development does not occur in universal stages. There is a need to fundamentally change the way programs use the GRR model with co-teaching and pivot from a large scale, universally normed programmatic structure, toward **an individualized, responsive, and flexible utilization of GRR.**
- University programs need to help **foster an increase in individuality** by creating spaces that recognize the individual teacher and support the creation of a community of learners who are both *living* in university teacher education programs, and *learning how* to support, excite, challenge, and ultimately provide rich educational opportunities of learning for all their students.
- If we truly wish to achieve the promise of **equitable educational opportunities** for all students, we must not neglect the need for pre-service teachers to also be given an equitable opportunity to develop a pedagogy that represents their uniqueness.
- Teacher preparation programs **can create both** a structure of support that is embedded with core principles around pedagogy and practice and still be intentional around creating the space that allows for the unknown, *never-repeatable* moments of individual development to occur.

Contact

Jeff Henning-Smith
University of Minnesota
Curriculum and Instruction
henni143@umn.edu
@J_HenningSmith